



STUDENTS and election clerks post signs outside a voting center at Los Angeles Valley College on Saturday.

Officials approve update to climate program

Critics say changes to state’s cap-and-invest plan are a significant retreat from mission.

By HAYLEY SMITH

In a high-stakes decision that will shape California’s economy for years, air officials late Friday approved a sweeping overhaul of the state’s signature climate program, cap-and-invest.

The 10-3 vote from the California Air Resources Board determines how aggressively the Golden State will curb planet-warming greenhouse gas emissions in the years ahead — and how billions of dollars in revenue will flow through communities, businesses and public programs statewide.

Cap-and-invest was nation-leading when it launched in 2013. The program forces major polluters to pay for their share of emissions by buying allowances at auctions or being granted them for free. It uses the revenue to fund public transit projects, wildfire prevention, affordable housing, clean energy, electric vehicles and safe drinking water.

The pollution limit — or cap — declines each year, reducing the total amount of emissions in the state and helping California reach its ambitious climate targets, including 100% carbon neutrality by 2045.

The Legislature voted last year to extend cap-and-invest through 2045. Officials at the Air Resources Board then spent the last several months drafting and revising the plan voted on last week, which received considerable feedback from oil and gas companies, envi-

[See Climate, A12]

Anxious and undecided, Democrats hold ballots

With state’s jungle primary, many hope to avoid having two Republican candidates for governor

By Hannah Fry

In a typical midterm year, Donna Layne casts her ballot long before election day.

But this time around was different for the 75-year-old Democrat. Late-cycle controversies and fear of a “wasted vote” leading to a lockout for Democrats in the race for California governor meant she didn’t make her final decision until Friday.

California Democrats have been wringing their hands for weeks about who would emerge as front-runners in the crowded race to replace termed-out Gov. Gavin Newsom.

The sudden departure of high-profile candidate Eric Swalwell amid sexual assault allegations and California’s jungle primary system, which sends the top two vote-getters to the November general election regardless of their party affiliation, added pressure for Democrats to coalesce around candidates who had the best chance of advancing.

“I was concerned,” Layne said as she slid her ballot into a drop box. “I wanted to make my ballot count and I was afraid that there might be two Republicans because they had been polling pretty high, so I wanted to be strategic about it.”

On Friday morning, voters — predominately Democrats like Layne — trickled into the Orange County Registrar of Voters in Santa Ana to turn in their ballots. A few told The Times they frequently wait to vote until the days leading up to the election so they can watch all the debates and get the most up-to-date information about the candidates.

But most said they hung onto their ballots this year for far longer than usual.

As of Friday, 19% of California Republicans had already cast their ballot, compared with roughly 16% by the same time in the 2022 primary cycle, according to data from Political Data Inc.

Meanwhile, only 14% of the state’s far-

[See Governor, A10]

How to train your robot, over and over

As tech firms forge humanoids, repetition and teachers are key

By Nilesh Christopher



PAUL KURODA For The Times

A TRAINER demonstrates the dexterity of a robot by twisting a nut onto a screw at Encord, a startup.

Fernando Flores can spend eight hours a day pouring the same cup of coffee.

He is not a barista. He’s a robot puppeteer, trying to train humanoids.

He manipulates mechanical arms remotely, using hand and arm sensors to make them pick up a pot of coffee, pour it into a mug and put the pot back in the coffee maker. Flores checks for spills, then empties the mug back into the pot by hand and does it again — hundreds of times.

“The repetitiveness, it can cause some discomfort,” said Flores, who has the title of senior robotic pilot at San Francisco startup Encord. “It becomes second nature after a while.”

This Sisyphus of Silicon Valley is on the front lines of a rapidly expanding industry of robot trainers, preparing to teach and operate the army of humanoid robots scheduled to march out of nearby factories in the coming year. Encord practices, records and sells data about

[See Robots, A14]

Longtime L.A. coalition feels the stress of voter frustration

Bass struggles to unite her traditional base as she faces attacks from both left and right.

By JENNY JARVIE

In 1973, Tom Bradley became L.A.’s first Black mayor by assembling Black, Jewish, white and Latino liberals into a coalition that ended decades of conservative white rule at City Hall.

Bradley’s election transformed Los Angeles politics and began what has been, for the most part, a 50-year reign of moderate Democrats. Year after year, the election map has changed, but liberal centrists have usually remained on top.

But as Mayor Karen Bass seeks reelection, she is struggling to unite her traditional base as she faces attacks from Democratic Socialists of America Councilwoman Nithya Raman on the left and Republican reality TV star Spencer Pratt on

the right.

Some political experts in L.A. say mainstream Democrats are floundering as they try to patch together their coalitions in an era when poll after poll shows the city’s residents frustrated with the status quo.

“Overwhelmingly, Angelenos feel Los Angeles doesn’t work,” said Fernando Guerra, founding director of the Center for the Study of Los Angeles at Loyola Marymount University. “You have this liberal regime that has dominated from ’73 to ’26 and it’s stagnant.”

Traditional voting patterns, political experts agree, are unraveling as L.A.’s mounting housing costs create new political fault lines in this city of 3.9 million. The devastating 2025 wildfires, along with enduring problems of homelessness, declining city infrastructure and traffic, have exacerbated discontent.

It’s still possible Bass can pull off reelection in the non-partisan mayoral race and

[See Voters, A11]

Trump’s polling sinks to a new low

GOP strategists fear the perilous milestone suggests his long-solid base is finally waning.

By MICHAEL WILNER AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — Mired in a persistent cost of living crisis and an unpopular war with Iran, President Trump reached a perilous milestone last week, registering an approval rating of 34% in a top-tier poll — a record low less than halfway through his second term.

The results mark one of the sharpest polling collapses of any modern president. The data, from the Economist and YouGov, bring Trump back down to his political nadir, matching a number he hasn’t seen since the immediate aftermath of the Jan. 6 attack five years ago.

It follows on several other surveys published in recent days showing the president entering precarious political territory roughly six months ahead of the midterm elections, raising alarm bells in Republican campaign offices across the country over the party’s prospects in the fall.

It has also led pollsters to question long-standing assumptions about the president’s floor of support, wondering whether it is at risk of giving way.

“It’s harder to get lower, but it’s possible depending on what he does,” said Christopher Wlezien, a political scientist at the University of Texas at Austin. “To get that number down, you are going to have to eat into his core.”

Trump’s base of support remains strong, reinforcing a long-standing theory among pollsters that partisanship now serves as a direct proxy for presidential

[See Polls, A8]

They escaped L.A., but not affordability crisis

By TERRY CASTLEMAN

They left by the thousands, giving up life in Los Angeles for new lives in places with cheaper housing and a more affordable way of life.

Some were almost evangelistic about how the move to places such as Austin, Dallas and Nashville would improve their lives and benefit their pocketbooks.

But it turns out it’s harder than many thought to truly escape the affordability

crisis that has long bedeviled the Golden State.

A Times analysis of the top 10 cities where Los Angeles residents moved between 2020 and 2025 shows that the cost of living in every one of those cities has risen more than it has in L.A. during that period.

Besides Nashville, Dallas and Austin, Texas, the cities surveyed are Las Vegas, Phoenix, Houston, Seattle, Denver, Portland, Ore., and Atlanta — all considered affordable alternatives to L.A.

In all cases, cost of living

— in addition to median rent and home price — was lower than in L.A. in 2020 and was still lower in 2025.

But the affordability gap narrowed in those five years, the data show.

In five of the 10 cities, median rent has risen faster than in L.A., where rents are up around 29% over the five-year span, The Times’ data analysis found.

In Dallas and Atlanta, rents are up by more than 39%, per Zillow’s Observed Rent Index.

In six of the 10 cities, me-

dian home prices are up more than Los Angeles’ 45% increase. In Phoenix and Nashville, home prices are up around 70%, according to Zillow’s Home Value Index.

The cost of living index developed by the Council for Community & Economic Research (C2ER) indicates that all 10 cities saw a bigger increase over the five years than Los Angeles did. In six of the 10 cases, cost of living increased at least twice as much as in Los Angeles, where it rose 3%.

[See Movers, A8]



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

NOT MISSING A BEAT

Celebrated singer Barry Manilow, 82, plots his return to the stage after cancer surgery. A new album is just the start. **ENTERTAINMENT, E4**

‘Alarming’ rate of suicides found

At least 10 detainees in Trump’s immigration crackdown have killed themselves in custody, report says. **NATION, A7**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 81/59. **B8**

Business **A13**
Opinion Voices **A16**

Plan to split L.A. city attorney job

During heated primary, commission pitches the idea of redefining the role. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



7 85944 10300 9